

TPL-01 · FREE TEMPLATES

Project controls execution plan

The plan that says which system is the source of truth for each field, and who is accountable when two systems disagree

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PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.
AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

A project controls execution plan states how a specific project will be measured: which structures exist, what the baseline is, how progress is claimed and verified, what gets reported to whom and when, how change is controlled, which system is authoritative for each field, and where artificial intelligence may and may not touch the numbers. This template gives the section structure and, under every heading, the prompts you must answer — not prose to be adapted, but questions that expose the decisions most plans leave unmade.

— About this document

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Project controls execution plan

In one paragraph. A project controls execution plan states how a specific project will be measured: which structures exist, what the baseline is, how progress is claimed and verified, what gets reported to whom and when, how change is controlled, which system is authoritative for each field, and where artificial intelligence may and may not touch the numbers. This template gives the section structure and, under every heading, the prompts you must answer — not prose to be adapted, but questions that expose the decisions most plans leave unmade.

Who this is for. Project controls managers and heads of project management office mobilising a project or a portfolio; cost engineers and planners inheriting a project with no written controls basis; and the project directors who will be asked to approve the plan.

— 1. When to use this

Write the plan during mobilisation, before the first baseline is approved and before the first report is issued. The plan is the thing the baseline and the reports are consistent with; producing it afterwards turns it into a description of whatever habits formed in the first two months.

Three other moments justify writing or rewriting one:

- **On taking over a project that has none.** The absence is itself the finding. Write the plan by documenting current practice honestly, marking every place where practice and intention differ, and presenting that gap list as the mobilisation backlog.
- **At a re-baseline.** A re-baseline changes what is measured against what. If the plan is not updated in the same approval, the next month's variances will be computed against a basis nobody has agreed.
- **When the delivery model changes** — a joint venture forms, a major package moves from re-measurable to lump sum, a second reporting entity appears. Each changes the source of truth for whole fields.

Do not use this template as a bid deliverable dressed as a plan. A controls execution plan that is written to be scored rather than to be followed is worse than none, because it creates a documented standard the project is then measured against and cannot meet.

— 2. How to complete it

Answer the prompts; do not adapt the prose. Every heading in §3 carries prompts rather than model text, because model text invites paraphrase and paraphrase hides the decisions. A prompt you cannot answer is a live issue for the mobilisation log, and writing "to be advised" against it is a legitimate and useful outcome — far better than a sentence that sounds settled and is not.

Name four things in every answer. The framework this series is written to treat detail as specificity: the artefact, the field, the frequency and the owner. "Progress is reviewed regularly" fails

all four. "The control account manager submits the progress claim in the progress measurement sheet (TPL-05) by 12:00 on the second working day after cut-off; the cost engineer verifies the evidence reference on every line above 500 budget hours" passes.

Fill the definitions section first (§3.2). Most arguments in a controls function are definitional, not arithmetical. Two people disagreeing about the cost variance almost always agree about subtraction and disagree about whether an accrual is in the actual cost. Settle those in writing before the first report.

Decide the source of truth per field, not per system. Systems overlap. The useful statement is field-level: commitment value is authoritative in the procurement system; actual cost is authoritative in the finance ledger; earned value is authoritative in the controls workbook; forecast completion date is authoritative in the schedule tool. Then state what happens when two disagree — who reconciles, on what cycle, and what tolerance is accepted without escalation.

Get it approved by the person who will be asked to overrule it. A plan approved only inside the controls function has no authority in the month someone senior wants a number changed.

Using the tables. The tables in §3 are pipe-delimited Markdown. To move one into a spreadsheet, copy the block, paste it into a single column, split on the pipe character, and delete the alignment row.

— 3. The template

Copy from here. Numbering is designed for citation — a change request can reference "PCEP §3.5" and mean exactly one clause.

3.0 Document control

Field	Entry
Project / contract	
Plan version and date	
Prepared by (name, role)	
Reviewed by (name, role)	
Approved by (name, role, date)	
Supersedes	
Distribution	
Classification	
Next review trigger	

Prompts. What event — not what date — triggers the next review? Which of the client's own controls requirements does this plan sit beneath, and where are the two inconsistent?

3.1 Purpose and scope of the controls function

Prompts. Which contracts, packages, entities and joint-venture interests does this plan govern? What is explicitly outside it, and who controls those? Does the plan bind subcontractors, and

through which contractual clause? Where the client has its own controls procedure, which prevails, and who has confirmed that in writing?

3.2 Definitions used on this project

Prompts. Define each of the following once, here, with the arithmetic where arithmetic applies: budget at completion (does it include the contingency reserve, or not — the choice governs every index reported in [TPL-07](#)); management reserve and who holds it; commitment; accrual; actual cost; per cent complete; earned value; milestone; float and who owns it; "approved change"; "authorised to proceed". For each, name the system that holds the value.

3.3 Structures and coding

Prompts. How many levels does the work breakdown structure have and at which level is the control account set? What is the sizing rule for a work package — by budget, by duration, or by both? Who owns the organisational breakdown structure and how is it mapped to the work breakdown structure? What is the cost breakdown structure and code of accounts, and how does it map to the general ledger? What is the resource breakdown structure? Who may create a new code, and against what test? Where are the structures published, and how is a change to a structure controlled? See [TPL-02](#) and [TPL-03](#).

3.4 Baseline

Prompts. What documents constitute the baseline, at which version, frozen on what date? What is the performance measurement baseline and what sits outside it? Where is the contingency reserve held, who has custody, and what is the release test? Where is management reserve held and who authorises its release? Which schedule is the baseline schedule and how is it identified in the tool? What is measured against what — is a variance computed against the original baseline, the current approved baseline, or both, and in which report?

3.5 Change control

Prompts. What are the approval thresholds and who sits at each? What is the routing and the target turnaround at each stage? Which form is used and where does it live? Who maintains the register? What triggers a re-baseline and what is expressly forbidden as a reason for one? How are pending changes treated in the forecast — excluded, disclosed separately, or included with probability weighting? Who may draw on contingency, and what evidence must accompany the request? See [TPL-04](#).

3.6 Progress measurement

Prompts. Which measurement techniques are permitted on this project, and which are prohibited? Where is the rule-of-credit library and who approves an entry in it? Who claims progress and who verifies it? What objective evidence is required at each credit step, and where is it filed? What is the cut-off calendar? How is level of effort treated and capped? What happens when a claimed quantity exceeds the budgeted quantity? See [TPL-05](#).

3.7 Cost management

Prompts. What are the sources for commitments, actual costs and accruals, and what is the cut-off for each? What is the timesheet discipline and who enforces it? Who reconciles the controls work-

book to the finance ledger, on what cycle, and what difference is tolerated without escalation? How are inter-company and joint-venture charges captured? How are currency and escalation handled, and on what basis are figures reported — nominal or constant prices?

3.8 Schedule management

Prompts. What schedule levels exist and who owns each? What is the update cycle and the statusing rule — actual dates only, or remaining duration overrides? What controls a change to logic or to calendars? Who owns float, and is it consumed first-come or allocated? What schedule quality check is run, by whom, and on what cadence? See [TPL-14](#).

3.9 Forecasting

Prompts. Which estimate at completion methods are permitted, and who selects? Who prepares the forecast, who challenges it, and at what forum? How often is a bottom-up estimate to complete required rather than an index-based extrapolation? How is the selected method recorded and how is a change of method disclosed? See [TPL-08](#).

3.10 Risk process

Prompts. Who owns the risk register and on what cadence is it reviewed? What are the probability and impact scales, and are they defined in absolute terms rather than adjectives? What triggers a quantitative schedule or cost risk analysis? How does risk exposure connect to the contingency position, and who makes that connection in writing? See [TPL-10](#) and [TPL-11](#).

3.11 Reporting cadence and distribution

Report	Data date	Issue offset (working days)	Prepared by	Approved by	Distribution	Classification
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Calculated column — issue date. In words: the issue date is the data date advanced by the stated number of working days, excluding weekends and the project holiday calendar. Spreadsheet, with the data date in [B2](#), the offset in [C2](#) and a named range [Holidays](#):

```
=IF(OR(B2="",C2=""), "", WORKDAY(B2,C2,Holidays))
```

Calculated column — working days actually taken. In words: the count of working days between the data date and the actual issue date, excluding the data date itself. With the actual issue date in [E2](#):

```
=IF(OR(B2="",E2=""), "", NETWORKDAYS(B2,E2,Holidays)-1)
```

[NETWORKDAYS](#) counts both end dates, so subtract one to express elapsed working days.

Prompts. What is on each distribution list, by name and role rather than by team? What is the escalation route when a report is late, and at what point does lateness itself get reported? Which report is the single authoritative statement of position, so that a figure quoted from anywhere else is known to be indicative?

3.12 Systems and data

Data field	System of record	Owner	Update frequency	Feeds	Reconciled to	Tolerance
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Prompts. For every field in the monthly report, which system is authoritative? Which integrations are automated and which are manual re-keying — and where a field is re-keyed, who checks it? What are the access levels and who approves them? What is the backup and archive arrangement, and who has tested a restore? Which data quality checks run, on what cadence, and who sees the exceptions?

3.13 Artificial intelligence: use and governance

The Institute's position is that artificial intelligence proposes and the professional disposes. Anything that reaches a report must be explainable, validated and owned by a competent human. This section makes that operational on one project.

Task	AI permitted?	Tool and version	Human validation gate	Validator (role)	Evidence retained	Data classification permitted
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Prompts. Which controls tasks may be AI-assisted — narrative drafting, anomaly detection in cost ledgers, schedule logic screening, document search, first-pass risk identification? Which are prohibited outright, and why? For each permitted task, who is the named human who validates the output before it leaves the controls function, and what does validation consist of? What project data may be sent to a model hosted outside the project's own environment, and what may not? How is an AI-assisted output labelled in the report, so a reader knows what they are reading? What evidence is retained so the contribution of a model to a reported number can be reconstructed at audit? Who is notified when a tool's model version changes, and does the validation gate change with it? On what cadence is this register reviewed?

3.14 Roles, responsibilities and RACI

Activity	Controls manager	Cost engineer	Planner	Control account manager	Project director	Finance
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Use R (responsible), A (accountable), C (consulted), I (informed). Exactly one A per row.

Calculated column — accountability check. In words: flag any activity row that does not carry exactly one accountable party. With the role columns in B2:G2:

```
=IF(COUNTIF(B2:G2,"A")=1,"OK","CHECK – one A per row")
```

Prompts. What are the delegation limits in value and in kind? What are the cover arrangements when the accountable person is unavailable, and are they named? Which decisions may the controls function make and which may it only recommend?

3.15 Interfaces

Prompts. Which internal functions does controls depend on for data, and what does each owe by when — finance, procurement, engineering, construction, commercial, human resources? Which external parties, and under which contractual reporting obligation? Where is the interface register? What is the agreed data exchange format and calendar for each? What happens when an input is late — does the report slip, or does it issue with a stated gap?

3.16 Assurance

Prompts. What does the function check on itself, how often, and who reviews the result? When is an independent review carried out and by whom? What is the health-check instrument and its cadence — see [TPL-15](#). What audit trail exists for a number that changed between two reports?

3.17 Mobilisation and closeout

Prompts. What must exist by which date for the function to be operating — structures approved, baseline loaded, rules of credit signed off, first report issued? At closeout, what data is handed back, in what format, to whom, and by when? What is captured for benchmarking and lessons learned, and who owns that after the project team disperses? See [TPL-16](#).

3.18 Appendices

Cut-off and reporting calendar · distribution matrix · forms and templates index · glossary of terms used on this project · list of open items from §3.2 onwards.

— 4. Worked fragment

Illustrative figures. An extract from a completed §3.11 and §3.14 for a fictional facility upgrade project. Dates use the calendar for 2026; the holiday calendar is assumed empty across the range, and the week is Monday to Friday.

§3.11 Reporting cadence — extract

Report	Data date	Issue offset (working days)	Prepared by	Approved by	Distribution	Classification
Weekly progress flash	Friday	+1	Planner	Controls manager	Project delivery team	Internal
Monthly project controls report	Last calendar day of month	+6	Controls manager	Project director	Client project manager, sponsor, function heads	Confidential
Cost-to-ledger reconciliation	Finance month-end close	+8	Cost engineer	Project accountant	Controls manager, finance business partner	Internal
Quarterly forecast review pack	Quarter end	+10	Controls manager	Project director and sponsor	Steering group	Confidential

Worked issue date for the monthly report at the May cut-off: the data date is Sunday 31 May 2026; six working days advance through Monday 1, Tuesday 2, Wednesday 3, Thursday 4 and Friday 5 June, then Monday 8 June. `=WORKDAY(DATE(2026,5,31),6)` returns **Monday 8 June 2026**. The May report in TPL-06 carries that issue date.

§3.14 RACI — extract

Activity	Controls manager	Cost engineer	Planner	Control account manager	Project director	Finance	Check
Submit monthly progress claim	C	C	I	A / R	I	—	OK
Verify progress evidence	A	R	C	I	—	—	OK
Post accruals at cut-off	I	R	—	C	—	A	OK
Approve a change up to 250 budget units	C	R	C	I	A	I	OK
Select the estimate at completion method	A	R	C	C	C	I	OK

The check column applies the formula in §3.14 and returns **OK** because each row carries exactly one A. The row "post accruals at cut-off" is the one worth arguing about: accountability sits with finance because the ledger is the system of record for actual cost under §3.12, while the cost engineer does the work. Writing it the other way round is the most common source of a month-end reconciliation that never closes.

— 5. Common mistakes

Describing the discipline instead of the project. A section that explains what earned value is has been copied from a textbook. The plan is not a teaching document; it says what this project does, at which level, with which technique, verified by whom.

Leaving budget at completion undefined. Whether it includes the contingency reserve changes every variance, every index and every forecast in every report. Two organisations can both be right and the joint venture between them will publish two different cost performance indices for the same month.

A source-of-truth table by system rather than by field. "Cost is in the finance system, schedule is in the planning tool" leaves commitments, accruals, forecast dates and earned value unallocated — and those are precisely the fields that get argued about.

RACI with two accountable parties, or with none. A row with two As is a row where nobody decides. The check formula in §3.14 exists because this is very common and invisible at a glance.

A reporting calendar with no offsets. "Monthly report issued in the first week" is not a commitment anyone can plan around, and it silently permits the data date to drift towards the issue date until the report describes a position nobody recognises.

An artificial intelligence section that lists principles. "AI will be used responsibly" is not a control. The control is a named task, a named validator, a stated data classification and a retained evidence trail. If §3.13 could be pasted into any other project's plan unchanged, it does nothing.

Approval by the controls function only. The plan's purpose is to be quotable when someone senior asks for a number to be presented differently. That requires a signature from someone senior.

— 6. Adapting it

Safe to change. Section order, provided cross-references are updated. The role names, to match your organisation. The number of reports and their cadence. The approval thresholds, which are project-specific by nature. Adding sections — contract administration, document control, materials management, sustainability reporting — where the project needs them.

Change with care. Merging §3.12 (systems and data) into §3.3 (structures) loses the field-level source-of-truth statement, which is the section most often cited later. Merging §3.5 (change control) into §3.4 (baseline) tends to lose the routing and threshold detail.

Do not remove. The definitions section (§3.2), the field-level system of record table (§3.12), the accountability table (§3.14) and the artificial intelligence register (§3.13). Those four are what make the document a control rather than a description. A plan without them will read well and settle nothing.

On a small project, keep every heading and let the answers be short. A one-line answer under a heading is a decision recorded. A deleted heading is a decision not taken, and it will be taken later by whoever is in the room.

— 7. Completion checklist

- [] Every prompt in §3 has an answer or a dated open item with an owner
- [] Budget at completion, actual cost, accrual and per cent complete are defined with their arithmetic
- [] Every field in the monthly report appears in the §3.12 system-of-record table
- [] Reconciliation cycle and tolerance stated, with a named reconciler
- [] Every RACI row returns **OK** on the one-accountable check
- [] Every permitted AI task has a named human validator and a stated data classification
- [] Prohibited AI uses stated explicitly, not implied by omission
- [] Reporting calendar has data dates, working-day offsets and named approvers
- [] Contingency and management reserve custody and release tests stated
- [] Change thresholds and routing agreed by the approvers named in them
- [] Approved by the project director or equivalent, not only within the controls function
- [] Review trigger stated as an event, not a date

— Related

- [TPL-02 – Work breakdown structure and WBS dictionary](#) — the structure §3.3 requires you to define
- [TPL-05 – Progress measurement and rules of credit sheet](#) — the instrument that delivers §3.6
- [TPL-06 – Monthly project controls report](#) — the output §3.11 schedules
- [TPL-15 – Project controls health check](#) — the assurance instrument referenced at §3.16
- [BPG-01 – Building a project controls function from zero](#) — the reasoning behind the sequence of §3
- [BPG-19 – Project controls assurance and health checks](#) — how to test whether the plan is being followed
- [AIG-08 – Governing AI on a project – the control framework](#) — the full treatment behind §3.13

— Sources and standards

- PCI Canonical Facts ([docs/publication-framework/00-framework/CANONICAL-FACTS.md](#)), verified August 2026: the Institute's position on responsible, governed use of artificial intelligence, from which §3.13 takes its validation-gate structure.

This template is an original instrument. Where the section structure resembles established practice, that is because the underlying activities — baselining, change control, progress measurement, reporting — are common to the discipline. No third-party plan, form or checklist is reproduced, and no standard is quoted.

— Status and version

Founding-stage document · Version 1.0 · draft · Reviewed under PCI governance. PCI makes no claims of accreditation or recognition beyond what is true today.